

Pope's scouts failed to locate Jackson's position. In the afternoon of August 28, a Union column marched unawares along the Warrenton Turnpike into sight of the Confederate guns on the ridge. Jackson could not resist the chance of a flank attack and opened fire. Soon the opposing infantry were engaged at close quarters around Brawner's Farm. Union Brigadier General John Gibbon's Black Hat Brigade distinguished itself in a fight that cost some regiments 70 percent in casualties. After nightfall the Union troops withdrew.

The next day, August 29, Pope raced to bring the weight of his army to bear on Jackson, assuming that the Confederate general intended to slip away, which he did not. As a result, Union columns were thrown piecemeal against Confederate defenders, who fiercely counterattacked. The most desperate fighting pitted Union Major General Philip Kearny's division against A. P. Hill, defending the railway cut on the Confederate left. Kearny came close to victory, but counterattacks drove the Union troops back.

Perhaps the day's most striking aspect, however, was the number of soldiers who did not fight. On the Union side, two corps under Pope's command failed to engage because of confused orders; and McClellan held back reserves of the Army of the Potomac. Longstreet's corps reached Jackson's right flank in the morning but, when ordered by Lee to join the battle, Longstreet demurred, and Lee did not insist.

On the morning of August 30, the Union assaults resumed with redoubled fury. Pope believed he was attacking nearly defeated Rebel units. But Longstreet was ready to intervene. He had placed his artillery in a commanding position on the right flank and raked advancing Union troops with deadly fire. When the momentum of the enemy attacks faltered, Longstreet unleashed his five divisions upon Pope's army.